

Board 1

North Deals
None Vul

♠ J 10 9 5
♥ 7 5 2
♦ 8 6 4
♣ Q 10 5

♠ 8 6 4

♥ A K 3

♦ K J 10 2

♣ A 8 7

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A 7 2

♥ Q J 10 8

♦ 9 5

♣ K J 9 3

♠ K Q 3

♥ 9 6 4

♦ A Q 7 3

♣ 6 4 2

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
	1NT	Pass	3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥Q

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥Q, dummy plays the ♥4 and West the ♥2.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=4 ♣=1 Total = 7

Needing two more winners you will have to make both the ♠K and ♠Q. This will only be possible if East holds the ♠A. Win the first trick (if you don't East might switch to ♣s).

East plays low.

A small ♠ toward dummy's honours, and it holds the trick.

You should take your four ♦ winners now, being sure to end up in your hand.

East plays low again.

Another small ♠ toward dummy's remaining honour. This also wins.

You have now won 7 tricks so don't mess around now. Take your two Aces and let them have the last four tricks.

If West held the ♠A you would not have made the contract.

A Simple Finesse has only a 50% success rate. That's why we only take finesses as a last resort.

Board 2

West Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 9 8 6
 ♥ A K Q J 4
 ♦ A 7 4
 ♣ A 2

♠ K J 5 2
 ♥ 7 5 3
 ♦ Q 10
 ♣ K Q 10 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A Q 7
 ♥ 10 6
 ♦ 9 8 5 2
 ♣ 8 6 4 3

♠ 10 4 3
 ♥ 9 8 2
 ♦ K J 6 3
 ♣ J 9 7

West	North	East	South
1 ♥	Pass	1NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			
3NT by East			
Lead: ♦ 3			

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♦ 3.

North plays the ♦ 10 and you the ♦ 2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=5 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 8

You need just one more winner. Since South probably has 4 ♦s you will not be able to establish a trick in that suit, so your only hope is the ♠Q. You win the first ♦ so they don't get a chance to switch to ♣s, a suit you are worse off in. Then take your 5 ♥ tricks, ending in dummy.

You can't put it off any longer.

North plays low.

A small ♠ from dummy, putting the ♠Q on. If it wins you will make your contract, if it loses you won't.

North held the ♠K so you were lucky this time.

But remember, finesses only work half the time. The other half they lose.

Board 3

North Deals
None Vul

♠ A 10 7
♥ Q J 10 9
♦ J 7 4
♣ 10 6 3

♠ 6 5 3
♥ 8 6 4 2
♦ K 6
♣ K J 5 2



♠ Q J 9 4
♥ 7 5 3
♦ Q 10 9 2
♣ 9 4

♠ K 8 2
♥ A K
♦ A 8 5 3
♣ A Q 8 7

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
	Pass	Pass	2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♥Q			

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥Q, dummy plays the ♥2 and East the ♥3.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=2 ♣=4 Total = 8

Needing one more winner you should see right away that it cannot come from ♥s, ♦s, or ♣s. That means you must hope that East has the ♠A. Win the first ♥, then play your 4 ♣ winners ending in dummy.

The moment of truth.

East plays low.

A small ♠ from dummy, and the ♠K when East plays low.

Unfortunately West takes your ♠K with the ♠A. He then plays another ♥ and you at least make 8 tricks but have no hope for a ninth one so you go down 1.

You probably thought since these Deals were all about finesses that they would work all of the time.

Welcome to the real world.

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A 7 4
 ♥ K Q J 9 7 5
 ♦ 8
 ♣ K Q J

♠ K Q 9 3
 ♥ 10
 ♦ K 10 6 5
 ♣ 10 7 3 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 8 6 2
 ♥ 8 4 3 2
 ♦ A Q 7 4
 ♣ 9 5

♠ J 10 5
 ♥ A 6
 ♦ J 9 3 2
 ♣ A 8 6 4

West	North	East	South
1♥	Pass	2♥	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			
4♥ by West			
Lead: ♠K			

West is to play 4♥. North leads the ♠K, dummy plays the ♠2 and South the ♠5.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=1 Total = 4

North found the best opening lead for his side, exposing your ♠ losers before you could establish the ♣ suit for a discard. If you start to pull trumps right away the defense will grab the ♥A, then take their two ♠ tricks and you will still have the ♣A that you cannot avoid.

Other than the ♦A the only useful card in dummy is the ♦Q so you must try to make a winner out of that for a discard.

You won the ♠A.

North plays low.

Win the ♠A, lead your singleton ♦ and finesse the ♦Q. Your luck has returned, the ♦Q wins.

Dummy leads the ♦A and South follows.

You discard one of your ♠ losers on the ♦A.

At this point you have not lost any tricks, and you can see that you have only 3 losers remaining in your hand. So you start pulling trumps and establishing the ♣s.

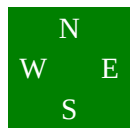
If the ♦ finesse had lost you would have gone down 2 instead of just one.

The risk was worthwhile though since it gave you your only chance of making the contract.

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul

♠ 6 4
♥ J 10 5 4
♦ 9 4 3
♣ K 7 5 2

♠ K 9 5
♥ A Q 2
♦ Q J 10 8 7
♣ 8 3



♠ 10 8 7 3
♥ K 8 3
♦ 6 2
♣ Q 9 6 4

♠ A Q J 2
♥ 9 7 6
♦ A K 5
♣ A J 10

West	North	East	South
			1 ♣
Pass	2NT	Pass	6NT
All Pass			
6NT by North			
Lead: ♠ 3			

North is to play 6NT. East leads the ♠ 3.

Winners: ♠=4 ♥=1 ♦=5 ♣=1 Total = 11

You need one more winner from the ♥ or ♣ suit. The straight finesse of the ♥K offers a 50% chance of success. The double finesse of the ♣ K Q offers a 75% chance of success. It's a no-brainer. Run 4 ♠s and 5 ♦s ending in your hand. Be very careful not to discard a ♣ from your hand.

You have run the ♠s and ♦s and are in your hand.

East plays low.

A small ♣, playing the ♣10 (or ♣J) when East plays low: the first of your two ♣ finesses. Let's say West wins the ♣K and returns a ♥.

West returns the ♥J.

DO NOT FINESSE THE ♥. Stick with your original 75% plan. Take the ♥A and play your small ♣, finessing the ♣J. This is why you couldn't discard a ♣ earlier.

The single ♥ finesse is an inferior play because its success depends on West holding a specific card, the ♥K.

The double ♣ finesse is much better because its success depends on East holding either of two cards, the ♣Q **OR** the ♣K.

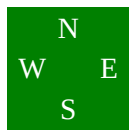
Board 6

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ 4 3
 ♥ 7 5 2
 ♦ A 6 5 3
 ♣ J 10 9 5

♠ K 7 2
 ♥ K 9 6 4
 ♦ 9 2
 ♣ K 7 6 3



♠ A Q J 10 9 8
 ♥ A Q J
 ♦ 8 4
 ♣ A Q

♠ 6 5
 ♥ 10 8 3
 ♦ K Q J 10 7
 ♣ 8 4 2

West	North	East	South
		2 ♣	Pass
2 ♦	Pass	2 ♠	Pass
2NT	Pass	4 ♠	
All Pass			
4 ♠ by East			
Lead: ♦ K			

North plays low.

At first you might think it makes no difference but, in fact, there is only one reasonable choice. If you finesse the ♠K successfully you may still have a ♠ loser. If you finesse the ♥K successfully you will surely still have a ♥ loser. But if you finesse the ♣K successfully you will eliminate your ♣ loser.

What a great layout! Three possible finesses and every one of them would work.

But as you can see, only the ♣ finesse will actually save you a trick.

East is to play 4 ♠. South leads the ♦ K.

North plays the ♦ 2 and you the ♦ 4.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

South has made another great lead. Any other suit would have given you a free finesse. You should duck the first ♦. It is very possible that South has led from ♦ K Q 10 and will be afraid to continue for fear you have the ♦ J in your hand. You'd be very happy to see him switch to any other suit. But he doesn't.

South continues with the ♦ Q.

You take it with dummy's ♦ A.

You are in dummy for the first, last, and only time. You need to try a finesse right now, but which one?